



Wanna know how you run?

RunScribe is a small sensor that can be attached to your shoe so that you see how you run in a three-dimensional view <http://dgit.in/RunScribe>

Predicting a suicide

Scientists are looking for methods to find the genetic basis for suicide which could predict the risk of suicide through DNA tests <http://dgit.in/PredictSuicide>

Business Laptops

₹1,20,000. We should start by telling you that all these laptops are good in their own regard. Each one offers something unique to the business customer in their respective price brackets, making them attractive in their own right.

Finding a single business laptop that can satisfy everyone from office interns to CEOs, or junior and mid-level managers to board members is an impossible task. Some of these laptops will be used out in the field, while others will only ever stay in air-conditioned rooms and cars.

We believe we have a laptop recommendation for every single one of these people who constitute a typical business setup. Read on to find out which one of these five laptops is best suited for your various business needs.

ACER TRAVELMATE P645

The P645 is understated in its design. It's not something that'll stick out in a crowd because its beauty is understated. It's a simple, black, rectangular slab that feels very well built and it should feel that way because Acer uses carbon fibre on the lid. The hinge is also very solid and as with the rest of the laptop, is just very simple and elegant.

The laptop lacks a touch-screen, which is quite surprising in the laptop space and especially on a device at this price – we don't think business users will miss the feature much, but it would have been a nice addition.

That said, everything else seems to be intact. You get a perfectly adequate CPU and a healthy, 8GB of RAM. You also get a lovely keyboard and touchpad, not to mention a fingerprint scanner and three USB 3.0 ports.

HOW WE TESTED

Initial setup: We tested these business laptops just like any other laptop we benchmark. All laptops to be tested are first examined and everything about them is catalogued, including bundled software, accessories, etc. We then completely wipe all data on the laptops and install a copy of the Windows 8.1 Enterprise Edition. Drivers and essential software are installed from the manufacturers' website before running Windows update. This is done to ensure that the laptops don't have any bloatware or trivial apps, only essential drivers that will help the device's hardware to run at optimum performance without any software bottlenecks. Finally, the devices are set to run in performance mode in the BIOS as well as in the power options. After this, the laptops are ready to go into the grinder of our performance benchmarks.

Performance tests: We conduct a whole series of tests on the devices to measure the impact of every aspect of the system on overall performance – tests that stress the laptop's CPU, RAM, GPU, hard drive, screen, thermals, battery, and more. These tests include industry standard benchmarks including (and not limited to) Futuremark's PCMark 8 and 3D Mark, MAXON Cinebench, and others. We use PCMark 8's Creative test suite to evaluate battery life of each laptop, as well. Results are carefully catalogued. Screen brightness and contrast ratio is measured using the Spyder3 Elite test unit.

A series of subjective testing is also conducted that scores aspects such as a laptop's keyboard, touchpad, palmrest, screen readability, onboard speakers, look and feel, among others. These tests help complete the gamut of objective benchmarks with real-world test scenarios, allowing us to take a fairly homogeneous look at the laptop's overall performance.

The final performance score is arrived at which includes the weighted sum of all the scores catalogued. Weights are assigned based on the perceived importance of the components. For example, since gaming doesn't really matter or all that important on a business laptop, gaming benchmarks and scores from them are of lesser importance here than they would be on a home entertainment or gaming laptop. Stuff like battery life, screen brightness, CPU performance will be of significantly greater importance in a business setup.

Features score: The features present in each Ultrabook are tabulated and given weighted scores depending on perceived importance. For example, dedicated multimedia keys and volume keys are given more weightage than those that are shared with Fn keys.

Design and Usability: The scores for this parameter are largely subjective as they indicate our experience with the device. Items such as quality of the keyboard, responsiveness of the touch-screen, etc. are weighted and scored.

Final score: The final score that we arrive at is the sum of the performance, features and design scores with a 40%, 30% and 30% weightage, respectively. This is not a fixed weightage, and depending on the category of laptops we're testing, these weightages can be different.

A note on winners: The Best Buy laptop is awarded to the device with the best price to performance ratio based on a pre-determined formula. This is the ideal, value for money product in the test. The Best Performer award is awarded to the device with the highest overall performance score. The Editor's Pick award is awarded to the device that the reviewer feels is the best product that offers something extra or unique that none of the other laptops have. The Editor's Pick is an entirely subjective award, the decision for which is based on the reviewer's experience while testing the products.

The most impressive feature on this laptop has to be the keyboard. People who really need to type a lot will certainly appreciate the luxury of a good keyboard. Of course, the keyboard on the Toshiba Protégé and Lenovo S1 Yoga are just a tiny bit better, but this is mighty close. The same can be said for the Touchpad as well.

The performance front is where things get interesting.

The device is powered by an i5 4200U, which is standard in this segment, but Acer's thermal management works very well, allowing the CPU to give its full potential, taking this laptop far ahead in our CPU performance benchmarks. At the same time, the battery life is quite good, with the device clocking in at a little over 4 hours in our tests. You can easily expect up to 8 hours of usage or more at

a lower, more forgiving power setting and use.

What's really disappointing for us is that a device this good ships with a screen that bad! A contrast ratio of 70:1 isn't inspiring, and neither is the max brightness of 94cd/m². The screen is just adequate for daily use. A better screen would have gone a long way towards improving the desirability of this device.